Inkwell | Product case study · Joshua Opel



LOCAL AI · PRODUCT DESIGN · CREATIVE TOOLING

Help writers find the story—without renting their imagination.

A local-first AI writing studio designed around author interviews, durable story memory, and the belief that the tool should maintain the system while the writer keeps the voice.

RESEARCH

Interviews with three published and independent authors

MY ROLE

Founder · Product strategy, research, design, and development

PRODUCT

Local AI planning, writing, revision, page design, and export

THE STARTING TENSION

Writing tools added a meter to an already vulnerable process.

CLOUD WRITING AI

Monthly cost did not feel proportional to the work coming back.

Every experiment spent tokens. Every rewrite raised the feeling of cost. Manuscripts lived on someone else's infrastructure, while authors still had to repair generic output and lost context.

∞ Ideas should be explored freely—not rationed by a usage meter.

Token anxiety
Writers second-guessed exploration because every prompt felt metered.

Context decay
Long stories drifted as characters, motives, and earlier decisions fell out of view.

Manuscript trust
A private creative work required confidence about where the text lived and traveled.

Generic output
More text was easy. More useful, story-specific thinking remained hard.

3

author interviews grounded the product direction

Inspiration stalls

The central idea arrives before the complete story does.

Details are difficult

Characters, motives, settings, and connective tissue take sustained work.

Writing is mobile

Ideas appear away from the desk—in notebooks, kitchens, and quiet moments.

THE CORE INSIGHT

Authors rarely lack an idea. They lack the details that make it hold.

> *"The difficult part is not producing more words. It is discovering the choices that make this story specific."*

01

A broad concept

A world, character, or emotional hook exists—but many foundational choices remain implicit.

→

02

The blank middle

Motives, relationships, constraints, turning points, and consequences need to be uncovered.

→

03

A story with gravity

Specific choices create a narrative that can support planning, drafting, and revision.

Product opportunity

Turn AI from a text vending machine into a developmental partner that asks better questions, records the author's decisions, and builds a useful structure around them.

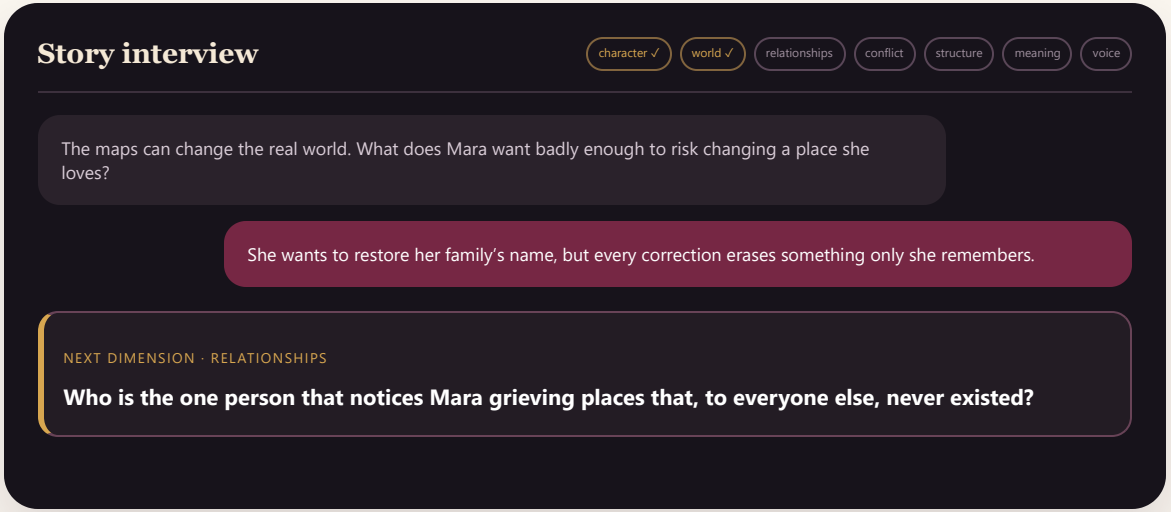
PRODUCT PRINCIPLE

Help the author think. Never impersonate the author.

THE FIRST PRODUCT HYPOTHESIS

Start with a conversation, not an empty document.

1. **Begin broadly**
   Premise, genre, point of view, and the seed of the story.
2. **Explore dimensions**
   Character, relationships, conflict, world, structure, meaning, and voice.
3. **Reflect specifics**
   Each question uses what the author already said rather than a generic checklist.
4. **Build the spine**
   Answers become the outline and Story Bible—not disposable chat history.



Breadth before rabbit holes
The interview maps the full idea before drilling into one intriguing detail.

One question at a time
A focused answer is easier than completing a giant creative questionnaire.

Author-controlled
Every answer stays visible, editable, skippable, and reusable.

THE ANTI-AMNESIA SYSTEM

The tool maintains the story. The model performs one task at a time.

WHOLE BOOK

Story Bible

Characters, places, themes, tone, style, and a running "story so far."

+

CURRENT CHAPTER

Planned beats

The immediate intent: chapter summary, events, and the next structural obligation.

+

LOCAL PROSE

Recent words

The nearby paragraphs preserve rhythm, grammar, and continuity at the cursor.

→

ASSEMBLED REQUEST

One bounded job

Continue, revise, expand, describe, summarize, or plan—using the context needed for that action.

Characters

Identity, role, arc, and fixed visual details

Locations + lore

Rules the prose should not quietly contradict

Tone + style

The emotional and linguistic register to hold

Running memory

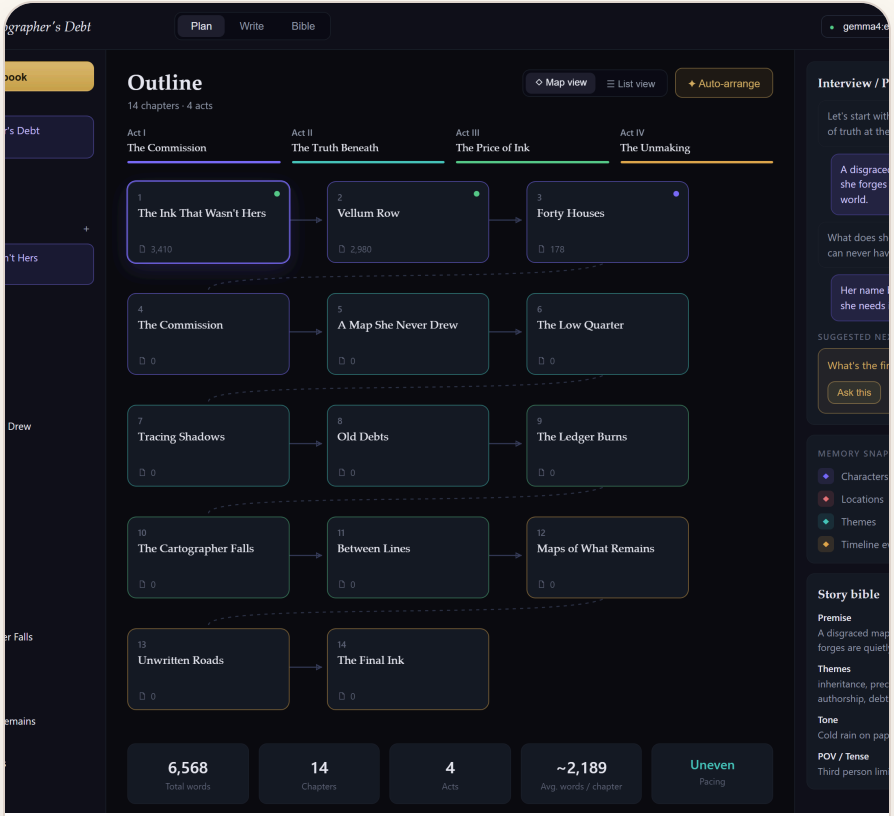
Earlier events, character states, and open threads

MY AI PRODUCT MANTRA

Have AI build you the calculator instead of asking it to be the calculator every time.

THE WRITING STUDIO

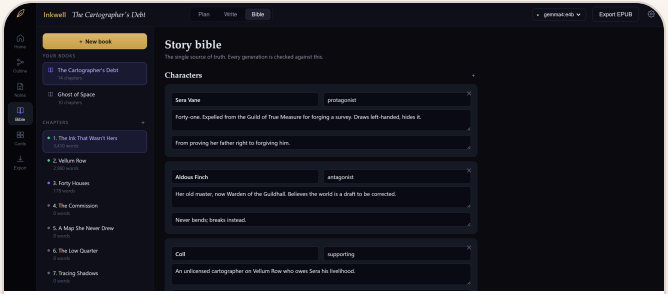
Structure, memory, and revision live beside the manuscript.



PLAN

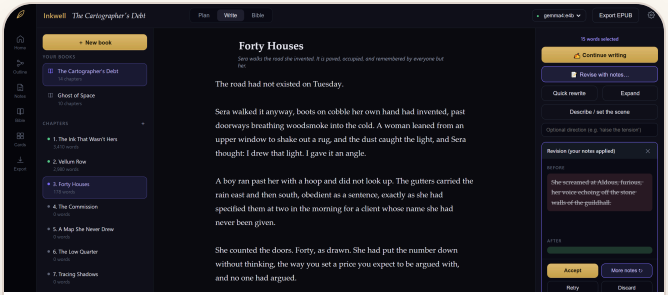
A navigable story spine

Act-colored chapters, causal beats, pacing information, and the interview remain visible as the story takes shape.



REMEMBER

A small, story-specific source of truth



REVISE

AI suggestions arrive as reviewable changes

Interview → outline
Planning answers drive structure

Notes → revision
Author direction stays explicit

Diff before accept
The writer keeps final control

Files on disk
Portable Markdown and JSON

REMOVING THE METER

Private by default. Unlimited by design.

Inkwell runs against a model on the author's own machine. There is no account, no per-word cost, and no need to send a manuscript to a third-party writing service.

AUTHOR

Browser or tablet

The studio works at the desk or elsewhere on the same local network.

→

INKWELL

Context engine

Assembles the interview, Story Bible, chapter plan, and local prose.

→

LOCAL INFERENCE

Ollama + Gemma

Capable local models support planning and prose without a usage meter.

No token anxiety

Explore, reject, and retry without mentally pricing every creative branch.

Manuscript stays local

The author controls ordinary files that can be backed up, moved, or versioned.

Lightweight product surface

The browser is the interface; one local service owns model and file access.

Desktop
Deep planning, drafting, and layout

Phone
Capture ideas when creativity is away from the desk

Tablet
Read, revise, and interview from the couch

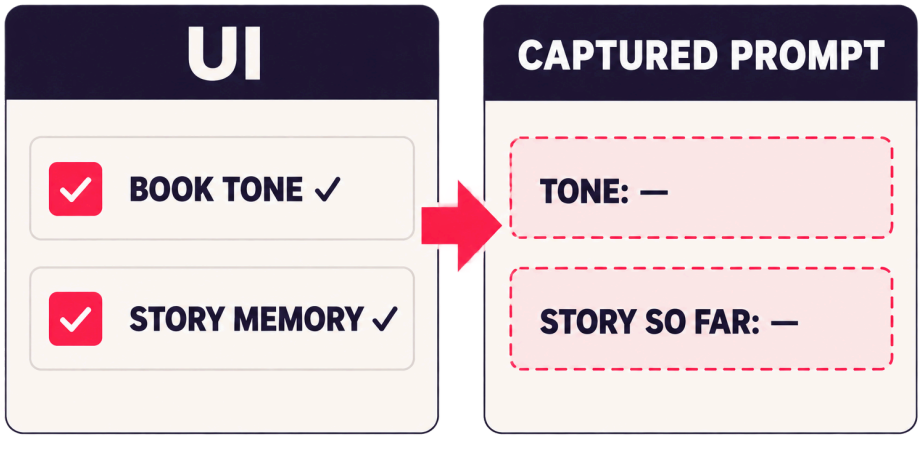
External access
Future work: secure use beyond the local network

DESIGN DECISION Cloud models remain an optional escape hatch for machines that cannot run locally—not the product's default assumption.

THE MOST IMPORTANT DISCOVERY

The UI worked. The model never got the message.

Book tone and narrative memory looked complete in the product. The output was close enough to seem credible. Inspecting the request at the model boundary exposed two different failures.



Conceptual visualization of the captured-prompt finding.

GAP 01 · TONE

Saved and displayed, but omitted from writing prompts.

The interface proved storage—not delivery to the model.

GAP 02 · STORY MEMORY

The prompt could include a summary, but the normal workflow never populated one.

The "send summary" switch had nothing to send.

THE FIX

Add tone to every writing system prompt. Connect chapter changes to summary generation and track coverage.

The memory display now reports what has actually been folded in.

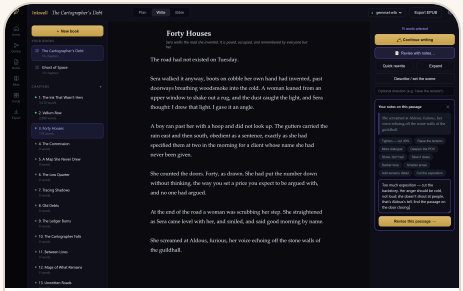
LESSON FOR AI PRODUCT TEAMS

Do not test only the interface or the answer. Capture and inspect what actually reaches the model.

EXPANSION THROUGH USER REQUESTS

The writing tool became a path toward a finished object.

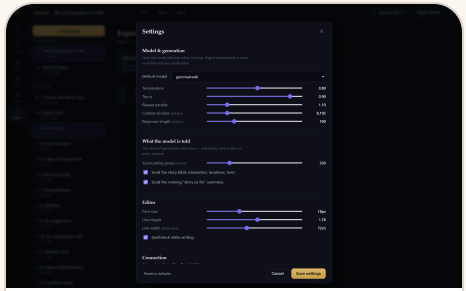
After the first release, users asked for artwork, chapter-head details, and more control over the final book. Those requests expanded the product from drafting assistance into page design and experimental visual publishing.



EDITORIAL CONTROL

Notes, revision, and diff

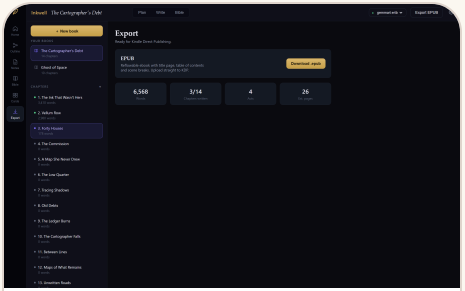
Writers direct the change and accept only the version they want.



PERSONAL SETUP

Model and context controls

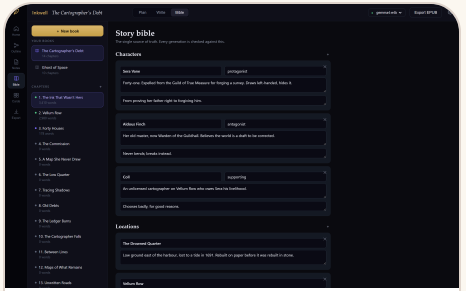
Local inference, generation behavior, voice, and memory remain visible.



PUBLISH

EPUB and page design

Move from Markdown files toward an upload-ready book artifact.



EXPERIMENTAL

Picture books + local art

Locked character and style descriptions support lightweight visual stories.

Chapter ornamentation

Unique lettering, symbols, and visual identity at chapter openings

Visual books

Spread planning, restrained text, and locally generated 2D imagery

Broader access

Secure ways to write outside the home network remain future work

WHAT INKWELL DEMONSTRATES

Good AI products do more than generate. They preserve intent.

Inkwell reframed writing assistance as a product system: help authors discover stronger choices, keep their story coherent, retain control of their voice, and understand what the model is actually being told.

RESEARCH

Start with the creative hurdle

Three author interviews shifted the problem from “write more” to “help me find the details.”

ARCHITECTURE

Make context a product feature

The Story Bible and layered prompts place continuity in the tool instead of hoping the model remembers.

VALIDATION

Test the model boundary

Plausible output hid broken wiring. Captured prompts turned intuition into observable evidence.

Product strategy · User interviews · Interaction design · Prompt architecture · Local AI research · Frontend + backend development · Testing strategy · Publishing workflow